that anyone who was so young and inexperienced as to get into that mess could be taken," speculated Kennedy. "And anyone who got into it and didn't see it through had no guts. So he just beat the hell out of me." Khrushchev did not boast about "beating the hell" out of Kennedy in private or public, but he told one of his advisers: "This man is very inexperienced, even immature. Compared to him, Eisenhower was a man of intelligence and vision."[17]

Kennedy felt destroyed both physically and emotionally. He had gone into the summit with excruciating pain in his back, which he had reinjured a few weeks earlier, and relied on a cocktail of drugs and hot baths to keep functioning. Now his back pain was worse, and he had to rely on crutches to move even a few feet. Although he tried to smile for the cameras, there was no way to hide his chagrin. On June 6, Kennedy admitted in front of a television audience that the negotiations had not produced the results he hoped for and that there had been no progress on the German front—the subject, as he said, of "our most somber talks."

Khrushchev returned from Vienna without the decisive victory he had hoped for, but in a much better mood than Kennedy. He called the summit a good beginning, and his Central Committee colleagues commended him on his diplomatic skills and "aggressive spirit." Khrushchev followed up on June 11 with a public release of the memorandum he had handed to Kennedy in Vienna, threatening to sign a peace treaty with East Germany in six months. It was another embarrassment for Kennedy, who did not mention the memorandum in his own address on the summit. On June 15, Khrushchev publicly attacked the "capitalist monopolists" for the lack of progress on negotiations concerning Berlin and once again alluded to war. "Surely, it is clear that a Cold War is a period of preparation, accumulating forces for war," asserted the Soviet leader.[18]

The possibility of war was very much on Kennedy's mind, and it frightened him. When Kennedy asked his military advisers about estimated losses in case of a nuclear war with the Soviet Union, he was given a number of 70 million people. Since the country's total population as of 1960 had been slightly more than 180 million, that meant every second or third American could die. One nuclear missile striking a major city would mean 600,000 victims. That number was comparable to total losses during